BONUS 3 · INTERNOMICS

The 5-Minute Pre-Conversation Prep System

Internomics: How to See the Game Behind Every Interaction

PAUL MASCETTA

The 5-Minute Pre-Conversation Prep System

Bonus 3 · Internomics · See the game before you walk in

Most people prepare for a hard conversation by rehearsing lines. What will I say first? How will I answer if they push back? What's the perfect phrase?

That helps a little. But you can have the perfect words and still be playing the wrong game.

This system prepares something more useful. Your read of the game. Who's really involved. What each person wants and what they're avoiding. What they'll likely do when you move. What they know that you don't. What makes your message believable.

Five minutes. Five question sets. One first move and one backup.

Use it before a negotiation. Before a hard talk with your partner. Before a performance review or a sales meeting. Any time the stakes matter.

> **The goal is not to script the conversation.** The goal is to walk in with a model of the game. Then you watch what happens and update. Model. Act. Observe. Update. Adapt.

The 5-Minute Routine

Set a timer. Spend about a minute on each block. You don't need perfect answers. You need honest first guesses you can test.

Minute 1: See the Game

- [ ] Who are the real players? Who can actually affect the outcome, including people who won't be in the room?
- [ ] What's at stake for each of us?
- [ ] What happens if we don't agree? What's my alternative and what's theirs?
- [ ] Who moves first and who responds?

Minute 2: See the Payoffs

- [ ] What are they trying to gain?
- [ ] What are they trying to avoid?
- [ ] Where are our interests aligned and where are they genuinely opposed?

- [ ] What would make this a good outcome for them?

Minute 3: Think in Responses and Manage Predictability

- [ ] If I do X, what are they likely to do? And if they do that, what will I do?
- [ ] What is their most likely response given their goals and constraints?
- [ ] What have my past actions taught this person to expect from me?
- [ ] Is that expectation helping me or making me easy to exploit?

Minute 4: Information, Credibility and Commitment

- [ ] What do they know or believe that I don’t? What am I only assuming?
- [ ] What would make my message believable to them? What would make it costly to fake?
- [ ] When they make a claim, why should I believe it?
- [ ] What commitment is real here? What actually binds them or me?

Minute 5: The Future and the Move

- [ ] What changes because there is a next time?
- [ ] Are we actually in conflict or are we failing to coordinate?
- [ ] Do I need a better move or a better game?
- [ ] What is my first move? What is my backup if they respond differently than I expect?

You probably don’t need all eleven lenses. Judgment means spotting the two or three that matter most in this conversation. Circle those. Let the rest go.

The Prep Worksheet

Fill this in before you walk in. Short answers are fine. Honest answers matter more than clever ones.

The conversation (who, when and what about):

The players (including anyone off-stage who affects the outcome):

What I want:

What I think they want:

What they're likely avoiding:

What they may know or believe that I don't:

My first move:

Their likely response:

My backup:

What would make me update my read:

Ethical check. Will this work? Should I do it? Keep those two questions apart.

☐ **Truth.** Am I saying only what I believe is true? Am I avoiding a false impression?

☐ **Autonomy.** Do they stay free to choose? Including to say no?

☐ **Dignity.** Would I be comfortable if they saw my full reasoning?

☐ **Informed choice.** Do they have what they need to decide well?

Notes on the ethical check:

The 2-Minute Debrief

Do this right after the conversation. Memory fades fast. The lessons fade faster.

What happened (facts only):

What surprised me:

Which assumption was wrong:

What I'll do differently next time:

What I learned about what they value:

> **Surprise is a gift.** If they didn't cooperate, ask what you misunderstood. If they agreed easily, ask what payoff you underestimated. Your mistakes are information. Don't fall in love with your diagnosis. Test it.

The Weekly Review

Once a week, look back over your prep sheets and debriefs. Ask yourself:

1. Which of my predictions were right this week? Which were wrong?
2. Where did I treat a story as a fact?
3. Which pattern keeps repeating in my conversations? What keeps it stable?
4. What have my actions this week taught people to expect from me?
5. Did any strategy "work" this week that I shouldn't have used?

30-Day Practice Plan

One focus per week. Small daily reps. Real conversations only.

Week 1: See the Game and See the Payoffs Before one conversation each day, name the players and what each one is trying to gain and avoid. Afterward note one payoff you missed.

Week 2: Think in Responses and Manage Predictability Before one move each day, predict their response before you act. Then ask what your usual reaction has taught them to expect from you.

Week 3: Information, Credibility and Commitment Each day separate one fact from your interpretation of it. When someone makes a claim that benefits them, ask what makes it credible.

Week 4: The Future, Coordination and Changing the Game Each day pick one recurring friction and ask whether it's conflict or a coordination failure. Ask once whether you need a better move or a better game.

The First 5 Questions to Memorize

If you only remember five, remember these. Ranked by how often they'll save you.

1. **What game am I in?** Everything else depends on getting this roughly right.
2. **What payoff would make their behavior make sense?** It turns "difficult" people into understandable ones.
3. **If I do this, what is it likely to make them do?** It stops you from winning the moment and losing the game.
4. **What do they know or believe that I don't?** Most bad reads come from missing information.
5. **Do I need a better move or a better game?** Sometimes the smartest move is changing the structure.

Stuck Mid-Conversation?

Things go sideways. That's normal. Here are six moves you can use live.

- **Ask instead of assume.** You don't know why they reacted that way. So ask. A good question tests your model in real time.
- **Separate the fact from the story.** Say to yourself what you know and what you think it means. Then decide how confident you really are.
- **Slow the game down.** You don't have to answer today just because they said so. Create a pause between stimulus and response.
- **Name the pattern.** If you're having the same argument again, say so calmly. A pattern you both see is a pattern you can change.
- **Check what makes the threat or promise credible.** Would they actually want to carry that out? React to the incentives and not to the intensity.
- **Make the next move obvious.** If you're failing to coordinate, say clearly what happens next and who does it. Clarity often solves what pressure can't.